

# American Political Divides and Great Debates

[84-309] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: August 24, 2026

Professor **Jonathan Cervas**  
Office: Posner Hall 374  
Email: **cervas@cmu.edu**  
Location: Scaife Hall 234  
Time: Tuesday & Thursday 2:00p-3:20p Eastern  
Office Hours: Wed 10:30a-12:30p & 1:30p-3:30p, and by appointment (ar-  
range via email)  
**CMU Academic Calendar**

TA: **Zakareya Hamed**  
Email: **zhamed@andrew.cmu.edu**  
Office Hours: arrange via email

The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus** can be found [here](#).

**Course Relevance:** DC: Perspectives on Justice and Injustice  
**Learning Resources:** All resources will be provided via Canvas  
**Prerequisites:** NONE

| August                           | September                     | October                         | November             | December             |
|----------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
| S M T W T F S                    | S M T W T F S                 | S M T W T F S                   | S M T W T F S        | S M T W T F S        |
| 1                                | 1 2 3 4 5                     | 1 2 3                           | 1 2 3 4 5 6 7        | 1 2 3 4 5            |
| 2 3 4 5 6 7 8                    | 6 7 8 9 10 11 12              | 4 5 6 7 8 9 10                  | 8 9 10 11 12 13 14   | 6 7 8 9 10 11 12     |
| 9 10 11 12 13 14 15              | 13 14 15 16 17 18 19          | 11 12 13 14 15 16 17            | 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 | 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 |
| 16 17 18 19 20 21 22             | 20 21 22 23 24 25 26          | 18 19 20 21 22 23 24            | 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 | 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 |
| 23 24 25 26 27 28 29             | 27 28 29 30                   | 25 26 27 28 29 30 31            | 29 30                | 27 28 29 30 31       |
| 30 31                            |                               |                                 |                      |                      |
| <div><div></div> in person</div> | <div><div></div> remote</div> | <div><div></div> no class</div> |                      |                      |

Why are Americans so divided — and is the premise even true? We spend a month on what political science actually knows, then the semester is yours: student teams pick the topics, assign the readings, and run the room.

## 01 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

| Assignment                                      | Percent of Final Grade |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>Attendance</b>                               | <b>25%</b>             |
| <b>Discussion Board</b> (before each class)     | <b>15%</b>             |
| <b>Student Led Topics</b>                       | <b>9%</b>              |
| <b>Surveys</b> (3: intake, midterm, evaluation) | <b>2%</b>              |
| <b>Book Review</b> (Slides + Presentation)      | <b>12%</b>             |
| <b>Op-Ed Project</b> (Draft + Review + Final)   | <b>20%</b>             |
| <b>Group Policy Brief</b>                       | <b>17%</b>             |

## 02 Due Dates

| Assignment               | Due Date                         |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Discussion board post    | 9:00 a.m., each class day        |
| Surveys (3)              | August 26, October 7, final week |
| Op-ed, first draft       | September 21                     |
| Op-ed peer review        | September 24                     |
| Op-ed final draft        | September 28                     |
| Book Review (slides)     | November 23                      |
| Group Project            | December 1/3                     |
| Group Project reflection | December 4                       |

## 03 The Essentials

- **Before every class:** one short discussion-board post, due **9:00 a.m.**, in Canvas.
- **Attendance is 25%.** The first three absences cost almost nothing; four to six is where a semester goes wrong.
- **Late work** costs one point per hour, but never drops below 50% — with one exception: the **op-ed rough draft (September 21)** loses 10% immediately, then 1% per hour, with no floor and no exceptions, because two classmates are waiting on it.

- **Devices stay in bags.** Non-class use of a laptop or phone means being marked absent for that session.
- **Surveys** and their screenshot receipts run through **Canvas, under Assignments.**

## 04 The Full Syllabus

---

Everything else — the week-by-week schedule with all readings, assignment details, and every policy — lives in the full syllabus:

<https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-309/readme.html>